follow certain standards and regulations for safety, health and working conditions. This does not help much, nor does it change much.

The hazardous nature of workplaces, including factories, has substantially reduced. There are some specific industries, such as mines, where working conditions are still hazardous but a great majority of workplaces are non-hazardous.

Recognizing this, the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020, should be replaced by a simple Hazardous Workplaces Code.

This law should define workplaces comprehensively to include all factories, mines, plantations, office establishments, mobile vending carts, working homes and virtual workplaces, etc. The law should thereafter strictly define what constitutes a hazardous workplace. It should require all workplaces to file a declaration whether they are hazardous or non-hazardous. Non-hazardous workplaces may be required to file only an annual declaration about their status. No other compliances should be required from them. If there are about 8 crore workplaces in the country today, more than 99 per cent of them would be relieved of any compliances.

The Hazardous Workplaces Code should classify hazardous workplaces into appropriate classes. For each such class, the Code should designate an authority to prescribe the safety and other measures the occupiers should take. The hazardous workplaces could be subjected to periodic reporting, which should be made exclusively digitally. All periodic inspections should be abolished. An inspection should be carried out, with full transparency, only in case of a complaint or when there is reasonable suspicion.

A Labour Management Law in Place of Wage Code and Industrial Relations Code

The Code on Wages (Wage Code) and the Industrial Relations Code are based on the basic concept of ‘employer-employee’ as the only or at least